

Day 4 — Empedocles, Aristotle, and the Greek Four

Module: Pañcabhūta (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students compare the Greek (Empedocles + Aristotle) four/five element scheme with Sāṅkhya, identifying at least three structural differences and one structural similarity.

Materials

- Printed extracts:
 - Empedocles fragments on the four roots (Kirk, Raven & Schofield translation)
 - Aristotle, *On Generation and Corruption*, II.3 (on the four elements + aither)
- Whiteboard
- Side-by-side comparison worksheet (blank)

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Recall: the 5-bhūta + 5-tanmātra + 5-indriya structure of Sāṅkhya.

Core (25 min)

1. **Empedocles in brief.** Read 1-paragraph paraphrase aloud: > Empedocles (c. 490–430 BCE) proposed four “roots” (*rhizomata*) — earth, water, air, fire. He added two forces — Love (*philia*) that brings them together and Strife (*neikos*) that separates them. The world is the cyclic combination/separation of the four under these forces.
2. **Aristotle in brief:** > Aristotle (4th c. BCE) inherited the four sublunary elements (earth, water, air, fire) but added a *fifth element* — *aither* (the “quintessence”) — which is the substance of the heavenly spheres. The four are characterised by pairs of qualities: hot/cold and wet/dry.

Element	Aristotle’s qualities
Fire	hot + dry
Air	hot + wet
Water	cold + wet
Earth	cold + dry
Aither	none (incorruptible)

3. **Side-by-side comparison.** Build with class on the board:

Sāṅkhya (India)	Empedocles + Aristotle (Greece)
Nu 5 mb	4 + 1 (quintessence)

	Sāṅkhya (India)	Empedocles + Aristotle (Greece)
er of ele me nts		
Or igi n	Emerge sequentially from <i>prakṛti</i>	Eternal “roots”
W hat dri ve s co mb ina tio n	Three <i>guṇas</i> (sattva, rajas, tamas)	Love and Strife (Empedocles); the natural motions toward “proper place” (Aristotle)
Fif th ele me nt ide nti ty	<i>Ākāśa</i> — universal medium of space, present everywhere	<i>Aither</i> — celestial substance, only in the heavens
Qu alit y- co unt rul e	1, 2, 3, 4, 5 (predicted from emergence order)	No equivalent — each element gets a pair of qualities (hot/cold + wet/dry)
Pe rce ptu al ma ppi ng (ta nm ātr a—	Yes — explicit, symmetric, one-to-one	No equivalent

	Sāṅkhya (India)	Empedocles + Aristotle (Greece)
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Inc	Yes (puruṣa, 25th tattva)	No
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4. **Discuss the most interesting difference.** Open: “Which of these structural differences feels most significant to you? Why?”

Activity (10 min)

Begin in-class comparison essay draft: - Pick ONE structural difference from the table. - Write a 1-paragraph (5–7 sentence) analysis of why it matters. - This is a draft for the longer Day 8–10 paper.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 5: “Tomorrow — we read SB 3.26.36 closely in IAST, word by word.”

Differentiation

- Tier up:** Read Empedocles fragment B17 (on Love and Strife) in translation; write 1 paragraph on whether the *guṇa* doctrine in Sāṅkhya is structurally parallel.
- Tier down:** Focus on Aristotle alone; skip Empedocles for now.

Teacher notes

- The asymmetry on perceptual mapping (Sāṅkhya YES, Greek NO) is the most distinctive cross-cultural point. Push students to notice it.
- Some students will be tempted to conclude “Sāṅkhya is more sophisticated.” Push back: *more sophisticated in what way?* (More internal symmetry, yes. More predictive of chemical behaviour, no.)

Citation(s) used

- Kirk, G. S., Raven, J. E., & Schofield, M. (1983). *The Presocratic Philosophers* (2nd ed.). Cambridge University Press. — Empedocles fragments.
- Aristotle, *On Generation and Corruption*, II.3. (Any standard translation.)